

Persona vs User Story vs Use Case

Three lenses on the same product — WHO the user is, WHAT they want and WHY, and HOW the system delivers it



User Persona WHO

WHAT IT IS

A fictional but research-backed profile of a typical user: goals, frustrations, context, skill level.

TYPICAL SHAPE

Name · role · goals · pain points · behaviours · a quote

EXAMPLE — MOCK-TEST APP

“Riya, 17, JEE aspirant in Kota. Studies 10 hrs/day, weak in Organic Chemistry, panics when a mock test score drops. Uses a mid-range Android phone on patchy Wi-Fi.”

SIZE

1 page per persona · 3–5 personas per product



User Story WHAT & WHY

WHAT IT IS

A short, conversational statement of one need from the user’s point of view. A promise to have a conversation, not a spec.

TYPICAL SHAPE

As a <persona>, I want <goal> so that <benefit> + acceptance criteria

EXAMPLE — MOCK-TEST APP

“As a JEE aspirant, I want to see which chapters I lost the most marks in after a mock test, so that I know what to revise first.”

SIZE

1–3 sentences · index card · fits one sprint



Use Case HOW

WHAT IT IS

A structured description of every interaction between an actor and the system to reach a goal, including alternate and error paths.

TYPICAL SHAPE

Actor · preconditions · main flow (steps) · alternate flows · exceptions · postconditions

EXAMPLE — MOCK-TEST APP

UC-12 View Weak-Chapter Report: Student submits test → System scores it → System ranks chapters by marks lost → Student opens report. Alt 3a: test partly unattempted → mark as ‘no data’.

SIZE

1–3 pages per use case · dozens per system



Think of a film: the Persona is the character’s biography, the User Story is the one-line pitch of what that character wants, and the Use Case is the full screenplay — every scene, every twist, every way it can go wrong.

Advanced view: how they differ and how they connect

Not competitors — they sit at different altitudes and feed each other. Pick the lightest one that de-risks the decision in front of you.

Dimension	User Persona	User Story	Use Case
Core question	Who are we building for?	What do they need, and why?	How exactly does the system behave?
Altitude / granularity	Strategic — whole product	Feature-level — one need, one sprint	System-level — every step and branch
Origin & method	UX research: interviews, analytics, segmentation (Cooper, 1999)	Agile / XP (Beck, Cohn) — placeholder for a conversation	UML / RUP (Jacobson, Cockburn) — formal, structured
Written by	UX researcher, product marketer	Product owner, with the team	Business / systems analyst, architect
Level of detail	Rich in context, silent on features	Deliberately thin; detail lives in acceptance criteria	Exhaustive: pre/post-conditions, alternates, exceptions
Lifecycle stage	Discovery — before scope exists	Backlog refinement & sprint planning	Design, integration, contracts, compliance
Testability	Not testable — used for usability review	Acceptance tests from Given/When/Then criteria	Test cases map 1:1 to flows & exceptions
Best when	Team lacks shared empathy; prioritisation is opinion-driven	Requirements change often; co-located agile team	Complex, regulated or multi-system flows; outsourced build
Failure mode	Becomes a poster nobody uses	Too vague → rework; too big → epics in disguise	Analysis paralysis; stale docs after the first change

HOW THEY CHAIN TOGETHER

Persona “Riya, JEE aspirant”



User Story “I want to see weak chapters...”



Use Case UC-12: 4 steps, 2 alternates



Tests & code Acceptance + flow tests



RULE OF THUMB

One persona per segment, many stories per persona, one use case per story that is complex, risky or regulated.

A story without a persona has no “why”; a use case without a story has no priority; a persona without either is just a poster.